



FIREFIGHTERS work to prevent flames from jumping between homes during the Eaton fire in Altadena on Jan. 8. Officials have confirmed 16 dead in the blaze. GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

Insurer of last resort may need a bailout

By LAURENCE DARMIENTO

The California FAIR Plan Assn., the state's property insurer of last resort, was born of smoldering ashes — not of a wildfire, but of one of the worst urban disturbances in U.S. history.

The Watts riots in 1965 damaged or destroyed more than 600 buildings, causing insurers to flee and highlighting the need for a new type of carrier to step in.

Established by the Legislature to also cover communities at risk for wildfires, the plan has proved resilient, paying out billions of dollars over the decades, including after the 2018 Camp fire that destroyed the town of Paradise and cost insurers \$12.5 billion.

Now, however, the FAIR Plan is facing its biggest crisis since the 1994 Northridge earthquake, when it was bailed out by the state's licensed property insurance companies, which operate the plan and provide it with a financial backstop.

The tremor caused some \$15.3 billion in insured losses for the industry, or roughly \$33 billion adjusted for inflation. But even after inflation, the Palisades and San Gabriel Valley's Eaton fires alone are expected to be [See **FAIR Plan**, A11]

A TOWN DECIMATED WITHIN THE FIRST 12 HOURS OF FLAMES

Radio reports, interviews illustrate workers' scramble to contain the Eaton fire's rapid tear through Altadena

By Terry Castleman, Salvador Hernandez, Matthew Ormseth and Grace Toohey

For those who first saw the flames from the Eaton fire, they looked small, even manageable.

But the winds in Eaton Canyon were clocked at 59 mph, sending a "shower of sparks" across the mountain.

Rocketing embers lofted by hurricane-force winds would eventually push west from Eaton Canyon into central Altadena, scorching a path of destruction that seemed unimaginable in a community not unfamiliar to wildfire. When the smoke finally cleared, 7,000 structures were lost along with at least 16 lives.

During the first 12 hours of the fire, numerous agencies would work together to try to contain it, including crews from the L.A. County Fire Department, the Pasadena Fire Department, the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection, Angeles National Forest, the Riverside County Fire Department, the Arcadia Fire Department and a Santa Barbara County task force.

It may take months, or even years, to fully understand why the Eaton fire was so devastating. However, an extensive review of firefighter radio transmissions

and interviews by The Times offer a view of how the fire spread over a period of hours, and the life-or-death decisions that firefighters, law enforcement officers and emergency personnel on the ground had to face.

The review found:

■ The fire immediately threatened hillside homes around Eaton Canyon. Firefighters got to the scene quickly and saved homes, but winds were by then pushing flames and embers west toward the heart of Altadena.

■ As the blaze grew, firefighting resources were no match. Aircraft were grounded almost immediately amid the intense wind, and fire operations became more about saving lives than protecting structures.

■ Embers traveled up to two miles to the west, passing over some neighborhoods but hitting central Altadena hard. Within hours, entire blocks were on fire.

■ Early the next day, fire officials realized mass evacuations were the only answer. With that, a sickening possibility set in: "I'm going to lose half of my town," Pasadena Fire Chief Chad Augustin recalled.

[See **Eaton**, A8]

Fire weather expected to return

Red flag warnings are likely for portions of Los Angeles and Ventura counties, and conditions could persist through Thursday. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Protecting your health

Beyond the most pressing dangers, wildfires can irritate your sinuses, eyes and more. Experts offer guidance for care. **WEEKEND, L5**

How did some homes survive?

By ALEX WIGGLESWORTH AND JOSEPH SERNA

They're calling it the miracle mansion of Malibu.

The beachfront house stands tall amid piles of rubble, still smoking from the Palisades fire, in an iconic image splashed around the world by news outlets.

But David Steiner doesn't credit his home's survival to supernatural forces. The sturdy concrete structure has a fire-resistant roof and tempered, double-paned windows. Firefighters stood on his balcony to hose down his and neighboring properties.

"I tell people it was great architecture, brave firefighters — and maybe a dash of miracle," says the retired CEO of Waste Management.

As stories emerge from the Palisades and Eaton fires of harrowing escapes, tragic loss and widespread destruction, others about homes surviving through some combination of fortunate timing, a lucky wind shift and — according to ex-

[See **Survive**, A11]

Trump to push executive orders

He plans to bypass Congress as he rolls out 'Day 1' plans. California says it's ready to fight back.

By KEVIN RECTOR

From the start of his campaign to retake the White House, President-elect Donald Trump promised to go big on his first day back in power.

In a series of early videos outlining his plans and in stump speeches across the country, Trump said he would use executive orders on "Day 1" to bypass the normal legislative process and secure major changes to U.S. policy with the simple stroke of his pen.

He promised to unilaterally upend the long-recognized constitutional guarantee of birthright citizenship by signing an executive order informing federal agencies that, [See **Trump**, A14]



J. SCOTT APPLEWHITE Associated Press

ORGANIZERS work to make the Capitol Rotunda ready for Monday's swearing-in ceremony, which has been moved indoors because of expected cold conditions.

Hostages' health a big unknown

As Israelis anticipate the return of many held, experts say physical and emotional care is vital. **WORLD, A4**

Quarterbacks key to success

Veterans Stafford and Hurts play vital roles as they try to reach another Super Bowl. **SPORTS, D1**

How Hollywood lost culture war

The industry reflects the Democratic Party's worst instincts, Matt Brennan writes. **ENTERTAINMENT, E2**

Weather

Partly sunny; cool. L.A. Basin: 61/44. **B10**

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